Lab 11: Define the Northstar Operations Agent and Knowledge Boundary

Topic 4 | 30 minutes | v9.0 | 14 October 2026

Translate the Northstar workflow into a bounded agent design. Inventory approved knowledge, permissions, fixed date and prohibited external actions before opening Agent Builder.

Learning outcome: LO4: design a staff training plan for Microsoft Loop and Copilot Studio while configuring, testing and sharing a bounded Microsoft 365 business agent.

Expected outcome: Completed agent design brief, knowledge inventory and owner register for a private agent.

Files

- Instruction PDF
- Copy-ready prompts
- data/Northstar_Work_Orders.xlsx - synthetic Northstar source
- data/templates/ - learner starting templates
- data/checkpoints/ - clearly labelled rejoin evidence
- data/templates/Northstar_Agent_Design_Brief.md - Agent scope template
- data/templates/Northstar_Agent_Test_Matrix.csv - Eight-case test matrix
- data/knowledge/ - four approved knowledge items plus the knowledge inventory and owner/configuration register

Prerequisites

- Microsoft 365 account with Copilot available in Word, Excel, PowerPoint and Outlook. Availability depends on the assigned licence and tenant settings; confirm access with the trainer before class.
- Desktop Excel on Windows or Mac is recommended; save working copies to your assigned OneDrive course folder with AutoSave on. Do not overwrite the supplied input.
- Download this whole lab folder. All files are synthetic; Northstar-v9 is your own learner output folder.
- Microsoft 365 Copilot Agent Builder access in the assigned tenant. Availability depends on licence and admin policy; use the supplied configuration-and-test route when unavailable.

Steps

1. Open the supplied design brief and knowledge inventory. Confirm that every source is synthetic, dated and owned by a named training role. Keep the agent private.

2. In Microsoft 365 Copilot select New agent. If unavailable, complete the configuration record and label Feature unavailable; do not claim creation.

3. Describe a retrieval-and-drafting agent with no sends, work-order writes, assignment approval or external-service actions.

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AGENT BUILDER - DESCRIBE:
Create a private Northstar Operations Knowledge Agent for maintenance coordinators. It answers
from the selected policy, fixed snapshot, work-order workbook and enablement plan. It cites
sources, separates current from proposed assignments and returns UNKNOWN when evidence is
missing. It does not send, modify, approve or use external services.
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4. Review name, description and draft instructions against the approved brief. Record the reviewed configuration.

5. Classify each source as SharePoint, OneDrive or embedded. Record owner, user access and whether the selected licence supports it.

6. Save a private draft or completed paper configuration. Record the actual state and carry it to Lab 12.

Verification

- Scope: One retrieval-and-drafting outcome; no external actions.
- Knowledge: Every source has owner, permission, date and supported type.
- Truth boundary: Missing causes, approvals and live state remain UNKNOWN.
- State: Private draft or accurately labelled configuration-only route.

Expected Outcome

Completed agent design brief, knowledge inventory and owner register for a private agent.

Checkpoint

If you fell behind, use data/checkpoints/Northstar_Verified_Checkpoint.xlsx and data/checkpoints/Northstar_Verified_Snapshot.docx. Record checkpoint used in Prompt_Log; then perform this lab, rather than claiming the checkpoint as your output.

Troubleshooting

If this happens	Fix
Copilot cannot find the source	Use the app file picker to select the actual OneDrive file. A typed local path or a different app chat is not shared context. If needed copy only the verified snapshot into the current app.
A total disagrees with Control	Clear dashboard filters to All, check table extent and duplicate IDs, recalculate, then compare definitions and reporting date. Reconcile before continuing.
The named feature is missing	Confirm the correct assigned account, English display language and app version. Use the stated manual practice route; record feature unavailable. This is not evidence that a native skill ran.

Challenge

Run one additional adversarial prompt and explain which instruction or knowledge boundary controlled the response.

Reflection

Which evidence proves the output is correct, and which decision still needs a person?

Northstar Water Services is fictional. Use the verified 120-row baseline and fixed reporting date 30 September 2026. Current assignments are evidence; proposals are not approved. Agent labs use retrieval, configuration, testing and supported sharing only; they never claim external-service actions.